CAR-08 · CAREER ROADMAP

The first ninety days in a controls role

What to read, whose trust to earn, and which numbers to verify personally before you inherit them

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AI proposes. The professional disposes.

Summary

On day one in a controls role you become accountable for numbers you did not produce and cannot yet check. This is a playbook for converting inherited assertions into verified positions before your name goes on a report: what to read and what to extract from each document, the ten numbers to verify personally with the test for each, whose trust to earn and in what order, what not to change in the first cycle, and the reconciliation that must tie before anything else is worth doing.

About this document

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Contents

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In one paragraph. A new controls role hands you accountability for numbers you did not produce, that were derived by people you have not met, from a process you have not seen. The first period is therefore not about impressing anyone; it is about verification, and about earning the access that makes verification possible. This document sets out what to read and what to extract from each item, ten numbers to check personally with the test for each, whose trust to earn and in what order, what not to change in the first cycle, and what must be true before you sign your first report. Its structure is the reporting cycle, not the calendar week, because the cycle is the clock a controls role actually runs on.

Who this is for. Anyone starting in a cost, planning, risk or controls management role — a first role, a new employer, a new project, or a sector move — and the managers responsible for their handover.

1. The inheritance problem

On your first day the project already has a budget, a baseline, a forecast, a risk provision and a reported position — all produced by someone else, much of it by someone who has left, and within a cycle or two it will be described as yours. From then on every error in it is your error, including those that predate you.

Hence the characteristic failure of a new controls professional: inherit the position silently, discover the problem later, and then have to explain both the problem and why you reported it as sound twice. The alternative is not to distrust everything loudly. It is to verify a specific, short list of things quickly, in a way indistinguishable from ordinary diligence, and to say what you found before you have signed anything.

Organise it in three phases by reporting cycle rather than by week, because how much calendar time you get before your first cut-off is an accident of your start date.

Phase 1 — before your first cut-off. Read, meet, and reconcile the budget. Nothing else. **Phase 2 — your first full cycle.** Run the cycle as it is run, verify the ten numbers in §3, and record what you find without changing anything. **Phase 3 — your second cycle.** Publish a position you have verified, and change exactly one thing.

2. What to read, in order, and what to take from each

The order matters: each item makes the next one intelligible.

The contract. Not a summary of it. Extract, onto one page: what triggers payment and on what evidence; what constitutes a change and who may instruct one; the notice provisions and their time bars; the programme obligations; any liquidated damages or bonus mechanism; and the definitions clause, because contracts routinely define "cost", "completion" and "programme" in ways that differ from ordinary use. That page will be consulted more often than anything else you produce.

The project execution plan and the controls procedure. What the function has committed to do, to whom, by when. The gap between that and what is actually happening is your first diagnostic and frequently your first improvement.

The breakdown structures and their mappings. The work breakdown structure, the cost breakdown structure, the code of accounts, and how each maps to the enterprise resource planning system and to the contract's payment structure. Ask for the mapping document; if none exists, that is a finding, and it explains most of what you will later discover about reconciliation.

The current baseline and the approved change log. Which baseline is current, when it was approved, and every change since. `BPG-04 — Baselining and baseline change control` treats the discipline; what you need on arrival is "what am I measuring against, and who agreed it".

The last three monthly reports, read backwards. Looking for two things: numbers that moved without explanation, and narratives that repeat unchanged across all three. A repeated narrative means either a genuinely static issue or a text box nobody updates, and the second is far more common.

The risk register and the last two review minutes. Whether risks are being retired, whether anything has been added recently, and whether the quantification bears any relationship to the contingency held.

The trend and change register, the pending items especially: their total value, their age, and what happens to the forecast if every one is refused. Then **the last audit or assurance report** — somebody has already looked, so read what they found, what was promised, and whether it happened — and **the cash-flow forecast against actual receipts**, to see whether it is built on certification or invoice dates and how the two have diverged.

The organisation chart and the delegated authority matrix. Who may commit money, up to what value, and who approves change — read against the approval trail on the last few change orders to check they agree.

3. The ten numbers to verify personally

Not audited — verified. Each can be checked in hours, by you, before you have any authority at all. Each is stated as the question, the test, and what a bad answer sounds like.

1. Does the budget reconcile? Test: control-account budgets plus undistributed budget plus management reserve equals the approved project budget, and that equals the contract or sanction value plus approved changes. §9 works it through. Bad answer: "it ties in the system." It either reconciles on a page you can show someone, or it does not.

2. Does actual cost reconcile to the ledger? Test: the cost report's actual cost for a stated period against the general ledger for the same period, differences named. Bad answer: an assurance that finance and controls "use the same system".

3. Do commitments reconcile to open orders? Test: the commitment register against open purchase orders and subcontracts in the source system. Bad answer: a register maintained manually in parallel, which is where cancelled and duplicated commitments accumulate.

4. Is the accrual complete? Test: take the three largest subcontracts and compare the last accrual against certified or measured work at the same date. Bad answer: the same round number every period.

5. Is earned value derived or asserted? Test: pick three control accounts and re-derive earned value from the rules of credit and the raw quantities. Bad answer: a percentage supplied by the delivery team and entered without a rule.

6. What is actually driving the completion date? Test: run the driving path yourself; check constraints, open ends, out-of-sequence progress and the data date. Bad answer: a critical path running through administrative activities, or one that changes character every update.

7. What is left in contingency, and is any of it spoken for? Test: the drawdown record — what was held, what released, on whose authority, against which risk. Bad answer: a figure with no drawdown history.

8. What is the exposure if every pending change is refused? Test: total unapproved change and its treatment in the forecast. Bad answer: pending change carried as though approved, with no separate line.

9. Is anything counted twice? Test: compare the risk provision against the forecast for events funded in both — the pattern in `CAR-01` §7. Bad answer: nobody has ever compared them.

10. Is the cash forecast built on the right dates? Test: whether receipts are forecast from certification, invoice or payment dates, and what the historical lag has been. Bad answer: the cost forecast with a fixed delay applied.

Write down what you find, dated, as you find it — not as an accusation but as a handover record. If the position is sound, you now have evidence that it was sound when you arrived, which is worth as much as finding a problem.

4. Whose trust to earn, in what order

Access makes verification possible, and access is granted socially before it is granted formally. Arrive with a question, not an opinion.

The project director or project manager. First, and within days. Agree the escalation contract described in `CAR-05` §5. Ask what they do not trust in the current reporting; the answer is usually specific and is the most useful thing you will hear in the first month.

The commercial or quantity surveying lead. They own the boundary of what may be claimed. Ask what is contested, what notices are live, and what they need from controls that they are not getting.

The finance controller or project accountant. They own the ledger you must reconcile to. Ask for the last reconciliation between the cost report and the ledger, and for the cut-off calendar finance actually works to, which is not always the one controls assumes.

Your counterpart in the other discipline — the planner if you are cost, the cost engineer if you are planning. Agree how the two positions will be reconciled each period and who resolves a disagreement.

The delivery and construction managers. They own the truth you are reporting. Go and look at the work, early, so that a reported percentage means something physical to you. This one habit does more for a controls professional's credibility than any analysis.

Procurement and expediting, for commitment, lead times and delivery dates, which drive the cost position and, on equipment-led projects, the programme; **document control**, who hold the evidence and know which registers are actually maintained, where an hour is worth a week of searching; and the **subcontract administrators**, where the cost risk lives and accrual accuracy is decided.

5. What not to do in the first cycle

Do not rebaseline. Whatever is wrong with the baseline, resetting it in your first cycle destroys the variance history that would have explained the project to you, and it looks exactly like a new arrival hiding an inherited problem.

Do not rebuild the report pack, and do not change the tool. You do not yet know which oddities are habits and which are contractual requirements, and every system migration proposed in a first month is a proposal to spend the project's attention on your comfort. Redesign belongs in phase 3 at the earliest.

Do not correct your predecessor in public. State findings impersonally and forward: the position, the effect, the fix. The person you criticise usually has friends who will be reviewing your numbers.

Do not promise a recovery you have not tested. Apply the plausibility test in `CAR-04` §9 before showing any recovery in any document with your name on it.

The one exception. If you find something material and wrong — material meaning it would change a decision — say so immediately, quietly, upward, with the evidence and your proposed treatment. Raising it early costs a difficult conversation; raising it late costs your credibility, permanently.

6. Your first report

Before you publish a report with your name on it, four things must be true.

The budget reconciles, on a page, per §3 item 1 and §9. **Actual cost reconciles to the ledger** for the period, with differences named. **You can trace at least one number end to end** — from a timesheet or measured quantity to the reported figure — and you know every hand-off it passed through. **Every judgement is labelled as one.** Anything accepted without verification is stated as inherited: "the risk provision is carried forward and has not yet been re-quantified" is an honest sentence that costs nothing and protects everything.

Include a movement bridge from the previous period (`CAR-05` §8) even if the movement is small: introducing one now is easy, whereas introducing one in a month when the number has moved badly looks defensive. Add a short "known unknowns" note — what you have not yet verified, and when you will have — which converts every subsequent discovery from a failure into a completed task.

7. The one thing to change

By your second cycle you will have a list. Change one thing, and choose it by a single criterion: which control would have caught the last unpleasant surprise on this project?

The answer is usually one of a small set — an incomplete accrual routine, a rule of credit that permits progress without evidence, a mapping that forces manual reconciliation, a cut-off nobody enforces, or a pending-change register absent from the forecast. Fixing one visibly, and showing what it caught, buys the authority for the next five. Attempting all five at once usually delivers none.

`BPG-19 — Project controls assurance and health checks` and `TPL-15 — Project controls health check` give the structured diagnostic, if you would rather assess the whole function than pick by instinct.

8. How this goes wrong

Signing the inherited position. The single most damaging first-cycle decision: publishing a report you have not verified, because it was the report the project already produced. From that point the position is yours retrospectively.

Verifying everything and reporting nothing. The opposite failure. A new arrival who spends three cycles auditing and misses two reporting deadlines has demonstrated the wrong competence.

Arriving with the last project's answers. Particularly after a sector move — see `CAR-06` §2. The method transfers; the benchmarks do not, and importing them makes you confidently wrong in front of people who know better.

Mistaking politeness for agreement. "We will look into that" is not a commitment. Anything that matters is confirmed in writing, in the ordinary record, the same day.

Confusing access with trust. Being given the files is not the same as being told what the files do not say, and the second only arrives once you have shown you will not use it against the person who told you.

Escalating too early with too little. A finding raised without a quantified effect and a proposed treatment is a complaint. Take the twenty minutes to quantify it; it changes how it is received entirely.

Letting the handover lapse. If your predecessor is still available, the questions worth asking are not about systems: they are which numbers they were least comfortable with and what they would have fixed next.

9. Worked example — the budget reconciliation that does not tie

Illustrative figures. Currency-neutral units, one project, at the data date of your first cut-off. Assumptions: management reserve is held outside control accounts; all variations listed are formally approved; earned value is measured to agreed rules of credit against distributed budgets.

The three statements you are given. Original contract value: 38,400,000. Approved variations to date: 1,150,000. Approved project budget therefore = 38,400,000 + 1,150,000 = **39,550,000**.

Sum of control-account budgets in the cost system: 39,010,000. Management reserve held: 400,000.

The reconciliation. Distributed plus reserve = 39,010,000 + 400,000 = **39,410,000**. Against the approved budget of 39,550,000, the gap is 39,550,000 − 39,410,000 = **140,000** — undistributed and unexplained.

The cause, once you look. One approved variation of 140,000 was added to the approved budget but never distributed to a control account. The scope is being executed and its cost is being charged, but no budget exists against which to earn it.

The effect on the reported position. Suppose 60 % of that variation's scope is complete. Earned value is understated by 0.60 × 140,000 = **84,000**. If the project's reported earned value is 14,200,000 against actual cost of 13,900,000, then:

Reported cost performance index = 14,200,000 ÷ 13,900,000 = **1.022**. Corrected earned value = 14,200,000 + 84,000 = **14,284,000**. Corrected index = 14,284,000 ÷ 13,900,000 = **1.028**.

Six thousandths of an index point, from one undistributed variation. On this project it happens to understate performance, which is the benign direction; the same error with the cost charged and the scope not yet started overstates it, which is not.

The second check, which is the one that matters. Is that same 140,000 also sitting in the pending change register? A variation that was approved, added to the budget, never distributed and left in pending change is carried twice in the forecast — and it will happen to every variation processed the same way, because the defect is in the routine, not in the transaction.

What you do with it. Not an accusation: a finding. The reconciliation, the cause, the effect on the index, the double-count check, and the treatment — distribute the budget, confirm the pending register, and add the reconciliation to the standing cut-off checklist so it is proved every period rather than discovered by the next new arrival.

10. Checklist — the ninety-day plan on one page

Before your first cut-off - Read the contract and produce the one-page extract in §2. - Obtain the breakdown structures and their mapping document, or record that none exists. - Read the last three monthly reports backwards and list every unexplained movement. - Meet the project director and agree the escalation contract; then commercial, finance, your discipline counterpart and document control. - Reconcile the budget per §9 and write the result down, whichever way it comes out.

Your first full cycle - Run the cycle as it is currently run; change nothing. - Verify the ten numbers in §3 and record each finding with its date and test. - Walk the work and compare what you see with what is being reported. - Raise anything material immediately, quietly, upward, with a quantified effect.

Your second cycle - Publish a position you have verified, with judgements labelled, a movement bridge attached and a "known unknowns" note listing what remains unverified and by when. - Change one control — the one that would have caught the last surprise — and show what it caught. - Capture two evidence records for your portfolio, per `CAR-07` §2, while the detail is still exact.

Ninety days is long enough to verify an inherited position and short enough that nobody yet assumes you built it. That window closes quietly and without announcement, and it does not reopen: after it, the numbers are yours whether or not you ever checked them.

Related

- `CAR-02 – Routes into project controls` — the gap you arrive with, which shapes what to check first
- `CAR-05 – Into project controls leadership` — the escalation contract and the movement bridge
- `CAR-06 – Moving between sectors` — extra first-cycle work when the move crosses a sector boundary
- `CAR-07 – Building a portfolio of evidence` — capturing findings while the detail is exact
- `BPG-04 – Baselining and baseline change control` — the discipline behind §9
- `BPG-19 – Project controls assurance and health checks` — the structured alternative to §7
- `TPL-15 – Project controls health check` — the instrument for that diagnostic

Sources and standards

Drawn from the PCI Body of Knowledge, principally Domains 4 (performance management, variance analysis and management reporting), 5 (cost management and cost control), 6 (earned value management and forecasting), 7 (contracts, commercial management, invoicing and revenue), 10 (project scheduling) and 12 (risk management for project controls); and from the PCL-AI competency set. All figures in §9 are illustrative and were computed for this document. No external market, salary or demand data has been used.

Status and version

Founding-stage document · Version 1.0 · draft · Reviewed under PCI governance. PCI makes no claims of accreditation or recognition beyond what is true today.